“hope” that there would be no further accidents that week. Rusk wanted to know how important the overflights were for intelligence gathering; whether it was possible to limit intelligence gathering to peripheral flights over international waters; and, finally, whether there was anyone among those planning U-2 missions who wanted to provoke an incident. The secretary of state did not trust his CIA counterparts![4]

Rusk was the first to speak at the meeting called by Bundy on September 10. “Pat, don’t you ever let me up?” he addressed General Carter. “How do you expect me to negotiate on Berlin with all these incidents?” Before Carter could say anything, Robert Kennedy, who apparently favored the continuation of overflights, responded to Rusk’s question with a joke: “What’s the matter, Dean, no guts?” But he had nothing to say about Rusk’s main argument: Berlin seemed to be a much bigger and more urgent problem than Cuba. Rusk wanted to stop overflights of the island but agreed to flights over international waters.[5]

Looking for a compromise, Bundy suggested that U-2 flights over the island could continue, but not along its entire length. Instead they should cross it to avoid being tracked and shot down by surface-to-air missiles. Besides, it was suggested that the flights would not take place if at least 25 percent of the island was covered with clouds; otherwise, the risk of overflights would not be justified by the received results of photo shooting. Carter was anything but pleased and considered that only a temporary solution. He told the gathering; “I want to put you people on notice that it remains our intention to fly right up over those SAMs to see what is there.” He got no response and complained after adjournment: “There they all go again and no decisions.”[6]

McCone, his French honeymoon paradise turning into a political cage, was more than upset. The possibility of Soviet deployment of ballistic missiles weighed on his mind. On September 16 he cabled Carter: “[W]e must carefully study the prospect of secret importation and placement of several Soviet MRBMs which could not be detected by us if Cuban defenses deny overflight.” McCone’s warning made no impact. The overflights were not resumed until October 14, owing to the prohibition and bad weather. The Soviets received a gift of five weeks to deploy nuclear-